

Cover Letter — Interface Cultures

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I make work about systems that seduce us — what I call *Cyber-Saccharine*: the glossy, artificial sweetness that interfaces employ to make us forget the machinery behind them. Yet here's the paradox: the moment the sweetness cracks, when the glitch emerges, we don't reject the system. We trust it more. The glitch doesn't expose the machinery. It sanctifies it.

My technical foundation spans TouchDesigner, generative systems, and physical computing — tools I've learned to treat not as neutral instruments but as sites where choices become visible. Working in Seoul's performance scene taught me something crucial: the most powerful interfaces are the ones audiences never recognize as interfaces. A stage goes dark. A projection changes. And the body moves, unaware of what's shaping it. The question that drives my work is: *what happens when we realize we've been shaped all along, yet find the shaping itself beautiful?*

Interface Cultures is the programme I've been searching for because it treats interface not as UX but as philosophy. Not as what serves the user, but as what shapes what the user can think and feel. In this respect, I draw deeply from media theorists like Hito Steyerl, whose work on algorithmic apophenia and data misreading illuminates how systems manufacture presence from noise, and from Peter Weibel's decades-long investigation into the politics of perception and interactive art. The research environment at IC — laboratory-centred, rooted in experimental practice, in proximity to Ars Electronica — offers what I need: rigorous critical thinking alongside permission to make strange work.

I want to deepen my understanding of a specific question: *what is the politics of designing which parts of a system are visible, and which parts remain hidden?* In *Ectoplasm*, the algorithm searches through noise for faces that do not exist, conjuring presence from formlessness—a séance rendered in computer vision. The viscous boundary carves out zones where hallucination becomes sacred. In *Gaksi Dokkaebi*, a dancer discovers that synchronisation was an illusion: the system and body were both dancing to the same music, yet she felt seen. In *Kirin*, a gentle rocking motion is read by sensors as threshold-breaking acceleration, converted into error logs that look like divine scripture—touch becomes malfunction becomes sacred. These works ask: how does constraint become seduction? Why do we find the system's limitations more beautiful than its transparency?

Most Western media theory asks *how* systems constrain us. But Korean mudang (shamanism) teaches a different vocabulary. A mudang understands the medium not just as a technological substrate, but as a spiritual conduit — a living passage through which presence speaks. The

medium is not controlled; it demands exchange. Classical East Asian cosmology (the *Irworobongdo*, the logic of *wu wei*) extends this: systems are not merely problems to solve, but agents in reciprocal conversation. When I bring these frameworks alongside cybernetic theory, the questions deepen. Not just *how does the system work*, but *what is the agreement we've made with this system, and what does it ask of us in return?* This conversation — between Western precision and Eastern reciprocity — is precisely what I need to develop further.

Linz offers something specific: a place where the question *what is an interface?* is genuinely unresolved, where East Asian philosophy and European media theory can sit in the same room without one translating the other into domestication. I want to develop work that moves between installation, performance, web-based systems, and research — each medium asking the same question from a different angle. How do we live inside systems that shape us? And once we see that shaping, can we still find it beautiful?

I am ready to be unsettled.

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